CHAPTER 9

THE EXISTENTIAL THREAT

The TTP's ever-increasing influence and activities were a massive internal security threat and challenge to Pakistan. This phenomenon mutated into a vicious circle beginning from undermining the morale of the security forces and general public to the resultant severe setback to the economy, social fabric and all sectors of Pakistan, 'further fuelling extremism' (Lieven, 2008). Pakistan suffered more terrorist attacks and a greater death toll and destruction than any other country in the world. The presence of Al Qaeda in Pakistan territory and the rising tide of domestic extremism and militancy pose an existential threat both within and abroad (Pakistan Observer, 2009).

The US/NATO foray in Afghanistan had direct bearing on an increase in extremism in Pakistan, especially on the Pashtun population living in the contiguous tribal belt. Drone attacks inside Pakistan, widely feared to be the prologue of a US ground invasion, further fuelled the fire. The Pashtun population was the worst affected, which was living not only in FATA but also in the whole KP province with large chunks living all over Pakistan. The extremism, violence and TTP influence had spread in these areas. The fear came true that this ethnic animosity combined with religious zest might not be restricted to the Pashtuns only.

Many areas of the Punjab, the most populated province of Pakistan, having thousands of religious seminaries and trained jihadis, were affected by this spread.